

Special Issue Editorial: Race and Educational Leadership: The influence of research methods and critical theorising in understanding representation, roles and ethnic disparities

Guest Editors Names/Institutions

Introduction

In 2020 the murder of an unarmed African-American man (George Floyd) in Minneapolis in the United States of America (USA) at the hands of a white police officer (Derek Chauvinⁱ) triggered anti-racism (Black Lives Matter) protests across the world. Since then, attention has been turned to education institutions with questions raised as to the number of non-white staff in leadership roles and the type of leadership positions they occupy (Author et al., 2021; Doharty et al., 2021). This was followed by calls in the UK to tackle structural racism and racial inequalities in higher education (Advance HE, 2021). This special issue commenced before this global scrutiny. It is concerned to better understand racialised leadership experiences through the research methods and theories employed by researchers to surface those experiences. However, its coming to fruition was affected by another global event, the Covid-19 pandemic (outlined in Liu, Kuo and Shih, 2020) which affected both the article authors and guest editors ~~were affected~~ to varying degrees ~~by~~. This collection is therefore a testament to the determination of the authors to complete their articles and contribute to knowledge production regarding the vital contribution the leaders discussed within make to educational leadership and the strengths essential to enabling them to perform the roles that they do, and in maintaining those positions. It also sheds light on the challenges that will need to be overcome if more individuals are likely to take on the mantle of being senior leaders in schools and higher education. Before turning to the racialised leadership experiences profiled here, we set out the background to the special issue and what we sought to achieve.

In English higher education Black, Asian and Minority Ethnic staff account for 10.3% of the staff population. They are underrepresented in senior academic and university leadership positions (both academic and professional services). This is particularly evident at senior manager (0.4%), vice chancellor and professorial level (ECU, 2014; Singh and Kwhali, 2015; UCU, 2016; HESA, 2019, 2020;

Advance HE, 2020). When professorial numbers are broken down by ethnicity this equates to: Asian 3.6%, Chinese 2.2%, Other 1.3%, Mixed 1.2 %, Black 0.6% (Advance HE, 2020). Notwithstanding, the underrepresentation for Black, Asian and Minority Ethnic female professors is even greater as attested to by Baroness Valerie Amosⁱⁱ who shared her experience of higher education meetings and stated that ‘in a typical gathering of 100 professors, 90 would be white and there would be just two BAME [Black, Asian and Minority Ethnic] women’ (Universities UK and NUS, 2019 p. 10; see also Rollock, 2019). Like higher education, Black, Asian and Minority Ethnic staff are underrepresented in senior school leadership positions in England; combined they account for 6% of deputy and assistant headteachers and 3.6% of headteachers (DfE 2020; see also DfE, 2018; NASUWT, 2017). Challenges for non-white staff in securing school leadership positions is an on-going concern (e.g., Belgutay, 2016; Miller, 2016, 2019a/b; Tereshchenko, Mills and Bradbury, 2020).

Leadership inequality is equally evident and has been experienced by indigenous communities and visible minorities in Canada (Smith, 2017; Trought-Pitters, 2018; Statistics Canada, 2019) and people of color in the USA (Howard and Gagliardi, 2018; McChesney, 2018; Gooden and Howard, 2021). An annual report by the College and University Professional Association for Human Resources (CUPA-HR, 2020) in the USA found that of nine areas of leadership responsibility in higher education ‘racial and ethnic minorities’ have greater leadership roles in three areas: fiscal affairs, athletics and research/health science, and of these three, have the greatest representation in fiscal affairs (28%) compared to athletics (11%) and research/health science (11%). Like ‘racial and ethnic minorities’ Black and Hispanic women tend to have greater leadership roles concerned with fiscal affairs, while least represented in external affairs (Bichsel et al., 2019). Interestingly, when compared to the USA population and the four-year college educated population men of color are under-represented in staff, professional, faculty and administrative roles whereas women of color are under-represented in administrative (-2% e.g., Provost, President, Dean) and faculty (-3% e.g., assistant professor, tenured full professor) leadership roles (McChesney, 2018). Despite such under-representation,

Black women had long held leadership positions in faculty and administration in Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCUs) as opposed to predominantly white higher education institutions (AAUW 2016). Black women's occupation of leadership roles in American higher education is not however, replicated to the same extent at school level, as only 1% are school superintendents (AAUW, 2016). Inevitably, people of color in leadership positions in the USA tend to occupy such roles in institutions where they are responsible for overseeing the educational outcomes for often marginalized student populations (Gooden and Howard, 2021) and in the UK, at the professorial level they are more likely to be employed in less highly rated higher education institutions (Advance HE, 2020). Regardless of where racialised leaders are employed as argued by Howard and Gagliardi (2018) they are essential to schools, higher education institutions and students who attend such institutions being successful. Indeed, they can make a vital difference in their career possibilities.

Existing knowledge about race and educational leadership (e.g., Khalifa et al., 2016; Author XXXX and XXXX 2018; Bush, 2019) supports calls for more information to be made available regarding racialised educational leadership practices and experiences. A recent international edited collection (Courtney et al., 2021) concerned with generating understanding about models and theories of educational leadership 'across the world' and promoting critical thinking, afforded Gooden and Showunmi (2021) an opportunity to highlight the salience of race and the interplay between race, power dynamics and educational leadership in the USA and the UK. In short they contend that the ways in which educational leadership is operationalised in local, national and international organisational contexts cannot be fully understood if race is ignored.

To date racialised leadership experiences in the public domain have largely centred on individual micro rather than macro experiences in schools and higher education institutions, and have largely been reflected in journals such as, the *International Journal of Qualitative Studies in Education*, *Ethnic and Racial Studies*, *Race Ethnicity and Education*, and *Qualitative Psychology*, *Advancing Women in Leadership Journal*, among others. Although publishing their employment experiences in

journals (e.g. Lander and Santoro, 2017), racialised leadership experiences in the UK (while generally given less attention) are more likely to be found in edited collections which focus on one area of education (e.g. Author XXXX, 2015; Gabriel and Tate, 2017; Author XXXX, 2018; Miller and Callender, 2019), in single authored books (e.g. Ahmed, 2012; Bhopal, 2018) and/or small-scale commissioned organisational studies (e.g. Bhopal, 2014; Fook and Nath, 2019; Rollock, 2019). Nonetheless, such publications powerfully articulate the perspectives and micro-aggressions encountered by non-white staff in educational leadership positions.

However, an under-researched area is racialised leadership experiences contextualised in part through the roles occupied and leadership strategies utilised (Miller, 2016), and the research methods/theoretical approaches employed in accentuating diverse racialised leadership experiences, and the strategies they employ. This is a key aspect of the articles discussed here, together with considering the salience of the research approach employed, researcher background/interactions/interpretations (Burt et al., 2018; Pringle and Booyesen, 2018; Fook and Nath, 2019) in enabling racialised education leadership experiences and strategies to be fore-fronted. This approach is essential because when empirical leadership experiences are reported, greater emphasis tends to be given to the experiences with less attention given to the methods and/or researcher background/approaches/positionality which are central to generating new insights into the 'how' and the nature of leadership practice (Foldy, 2009; Gooden and Showunmi, 2021). Moreover, Lumby and Morrison argue that when researching leadership, researchers should have a 'secure sense of which methods or tools will suffice, since it is the relationship between epistemology, methodology, and tools or methods which gives research its intellectual credibility and legitimacy' (Lumby and Morrison, 2010: 9). Further, they observe that if diversity leadership issues are to be brought in 'from the periphery to the mainstream ... a leap in the innovative and creative use of theory and method will be needed to dent the current habitual modes of research and practice' (Lumby and Morrison, 2010: 13). A similar message is echoed in Stanfield's (2016) edited collection which calls for an understanding of the methodological approaches that

researchers employ when researching race and leadership in education, and by Pringle and Strachan (2015) who advocate understanding research into leadership experiences which 'take into account, intersecting identities, global influences, theory and organisational applications' (Pringle and Strachan, 2015: 53, cited by Pringle and Booysen, 2018: 20).

Research concerning race, education and leadership and that is concerned with surfacing and addressing inequality is usually underpinned by a social justice, critical and transformative perspective as exemplified by critical race theory which has its roots in American legal studies (see detail in e.g., Ladson-Billings, 1998) and has increasingly been applied in the UK to understand racialised experiences in education (e.g., Gillborn et al., 2017; Lander and Santoro, 2017; Warmington, 2020). This theoretical framework favours the qualitative approach which allows for in-depth research and analyses of human experiences (Author XXXX, 2011). CRT scholars view storytelling as pertinent to such understandings and to generating new racialised insights, especially pertaining to the double or multiple consciousness influencing the how of people of colour's educational leadership (Chapman et al., 2019). Equally, storytelling is deemed a method of resistance with the result being the counter-story which is defined as:

a method of telling the stories of those people whose experiences are not often told. ...The counter-story is also a tool for exposing, analysing and challenging the majoritarian stories of racial privilege. Counter-stories can shatter complacency, challenge the dominant discourse on race, and further the struggle for racial reform. ... within the histories and lives of people of color, there are numerous unheard counter-stories. Storytelling and counter-storytelling these experiences can help strengthen traditions of social, political and cultural survival and resistance (Solórzano and Yosso, 2016: 133).

Counter-storytelling has four key functions:

- a) They can build a community among those at the margins of society by putting a human and familiar face to educational theory and practice, b) they can challenge the perceived

wisdom of those at society's centre by providing a context to understand and transform established belief systems, c) they can open new windows into the reality of those at the margins of society by showing possibilities beyond the ones they live and demonstrating that they are not alone in their position, d) they can teach others that by combining elements from both the story and the current reality, one can construct another world that is richer than either the story or the reality alone' (Solórzano and Yosso, 2016: 136).

Counter-storytelling 'highlights the nuances of the lived experiences that are designed to debunk myths and challenge misconceptions of oppressed peoples' (Berry and Cook, 2019: 91). Solórzano and Yosso (2016) also point to the importance of counter-storytelling as an analytical framework for educational research (p.127). They contend that:

when the ideology of racism is examined and racist injustices are named, victims of racism can find their voice. Furthermore, those injured by racism and other forms of oppression discover they are not alone in their marginality. They become empowered participants, hearing their own stories and the stories of others, listening to how the arguments against them are framed, and learning to make the arguments to defend themselves (Solórzano and Yosso, 2016: 129).

Counter-storytelling thus gives voice and strength to communities of color as 'the locus of power in the research process' is shifted to 'situating subjects as knowers' (Pillow, 2003: 187, cited by Chapman et al., 2019: 98). Indeed, much leadership research has tended to be individualised or small-scale, often derived from interviews, focus groups and reflective journals (Lumby and Morrison, 2010). Notwithstanding, its commitment to individual/group storytelling, some CRT scholars have turned their attention to the ability of quantitative research to generate sufficient understanding about racialised experiences within education (e.g., Gillborn, 2010). Specifically, Garcia, López and Vélez (2018:150) asked 'can quantitative methods long critiqued for their inability

to capture the nuance of everyday experience, support and further a critical race agenda in educational research?’ Key difficulties raised about quantitative research when investigating racial issues are that:

The centrality of racism as a complex and deeply rooted aspect of society is not readily amenable to quantification; numbers are not neutral and should be interrogated for their role in promoting deficit analyses that serve White racial interests; categories are neither ‘natural’ nor given and so the units and forms of analysis must be critically evaluated; voice and insight are vital: data cannot ‘speak for itself’ and critical analyses should be informed by the experiential knowledge of marginalized groups (Gillborn, Warmington and Demack, 2018: 158).

Interestingly, while these authors contend that quantitative research is not objective (as researchers bring their biased positions to the data collection and analysis) and consider ‘statistical analyses [to] have no inherent value’, they suggest it ‘can play a role in struggles for social justice’ (Gillborn, Warmington and Demack, 2018:158; see also DeCuir-Gunby, Chapman and Schutz, 2019). This suggests that different types of methodological approaches can inform new understandings of race and leadership in education.

Aims

We sought to examine:

- Ethnic representation and disparities in educational leadership;
- Research approaches and theoretical frameworks used to make visible the racialised experiences of leadership staff in school and higher education and allow marginalised voices to be heard;
- The educational contexts in which racialised leaders operate and the ‘how’ of their leadership practice and impact;

- The effects of race/ethnicity on the perceptions of leadership, actions in leadership and approaches to the reality of race/ethnicity; and
- Leadership/power and institutionalized inequities - how these are resisted and the possibilities for transformation of racialised leadership.

Provided is a nuanced and richer understanding of the studies conducted to comprehend their everyday realities, the numbers in leadership positions, progression experiences combined with comprehending the policy changes required to increase the number of racially diverse staff in leadership positions and transform their experiences.

Light is shed on racialised leadership in school and higher education in diverse geographical and educational contexts of England, Canada, America and South Africa. The centring of educational leaders' lived experiences and their voices are prioritised alongside the research methods (phenomenological, longitudinal, documentary, semi-structured interviews), analytical (content and textual analysis) and theoretical approaches (CRT, critical ecological) used to illuminate the nuances associated with race and educational leadership in schools and higher education. The prism of race enables us to add new educational leadership insights to the field associated with ethnicity, gender, culturally constructed notions of leadership, intersectionality (Crenshaw, 2019) and/or geographical location. The findings highlight implications for researching race and educational leadership.

Articles

Six articles are featured: two provide insights into school leadership and four higher education, and of the four, three interrogate Black women's leadership. Combined, the articles interrogate the complexity of race and racism experienced in educational leadership, development of anti-racist leadership practices and support earlier contentions that educational leadership cannot be

separated from leaders 'backgrounds, social identities and/or earlier knowledge' (Pringle and Booysen, 2018:32).

With the first article attention turns to leadership in Canada. **Wendy Cukier, Patience Adamu, Charlie Wall-Andrews and Mohamed Elmi's** article - '*Racialized Leaders Leading Ontario Universities*' uses a critical ecology systems model approach with a dataset of 324 academics to identify individual (e.g. bias, perceptions and choices), organisational (e.g. norms, recruitment, support teaching, learning and research) and societal (e.g. policies, programmes, stereotypes and culture) factors that account for the under-representation of senior leaders including presidents and provosts in Canadian universities in Ontario, despite a fifth of the university population coming from racialised communities, and universities having expressed commitments to diversity and inclusion. In common with findings in the UK (e.g., Advance HE, 2020) their findings suggest that the more senior non-white academics become the less likely they are to occupy the highest positions, which is also reflective of their experiences in the wider society.

While Cukier et al's article identifies factors affecting recruitment, the second article by **Crasha Townsend** - '*Identity politics: Why African American women are missing in administrative leadership in public higher education*', illuminates retention challenges experienced by five Black women administrators at director-level at predominantly white higher education institutions in the USA. Through phenomenological inquiry and CRT these Black women's counter-narratives explain how as well as constantly having to prove their ability to justify their employment, they experienced their authority being questioned and they endured extra time-consuming workload which the author has deemed a 'Black tax' (e.g., 'being on multiple committees to ensure a voice of color is present, mentoring students of color, being the "fixer" of problems on campus, and navigating issues around racism'). They were overly scrutinised and experienced promotion and self-identity challenges which meant that rather than bringing their 'authentic' selves (Goffman, 1959) to work they filtered and considered carefully, the type of 'work self' (including how they dressed, styled their hair and spoke)

they put into the public domain. While Townsend's study is filled with leadership challenges, the how of the women's leadership is underpinned by their caring ('Black tax') roles.

The third article by **Nuchelle Chance** – '*A phenomenological inquiry into the influence of crucible experiences on the leadership development of Black women in higher education senior leadership*' continues the focus on identity politics. It illustrates the salience of adopting a phenomenological approach to qualitatively investigate the resilience identities that a group of Black women bring to their leadership roles as vice-presidents, presidents and provosts of a 4-year college or university in the USA, and how such resilience becomes transformative and is utilised in further enabling them to develop their leadership roles. These resilience identities are grounded in adverse personal lived experiences (e.g., physical, sexual, verbal assault/abuse, bullying, discrimination, poverty, being raised by a single parent, family bereavement, and health issues) encountered by these senior leaders as children and during adulthood, and which are brought to the surface through application of Bennis and Thomas's (2002) 'crucibles of leadership theory'. Chance found that these women leaders used severely adverse personal experiences and the knowledge of how they overcame them to develop leadership qualities, progress and survive in higher education. Also crucial to such understandings is how Black women presidents/provosts use their experiences to help support and promote leadership in the next generation of Black women leaders.

The fourth article by **Natasha Johnson** – '*Balancing race, gender, and responsibility: Conversations with four Black women in educational leadership in the United States of America*', continues with the spotlight on leadership identity in American higher education; specifically, intersectionality between race and gender, and balancing Black women's senior leadership responsibilities with equitable, social justice leadership. Through in-depth interviews/storytelling and hermeneutic phenomenology, the impact of race and gender on Black women's leadership ability and capability to perform at the highest levels in higher education is examined. The article illuminates the women's reflections on how the intersection of their raced and gendered identity enabled them to successfully navigate the

highest levels of the educational leadership sphere in which they are underrepresented. Johnson concludes with a call for more research specific to the intricacies of Black women's leadership journeys in American higher education.

Moving from higher education to school leadership the fifth article by **Pontso Moorosi** – *Colour-blind leadership policy: A critical race theory analysis of school principalship standards in South Africa*, combines content analysis with CRT to examine the role of school principalship standards in addressing issues of race in South African educational leadership, and preparing future school leaders. Through the application of CRT, the analysis reveals that even in a majority Black country there is no explicit reference to 'race' and 'ethnicity' as social constructs in the principalship standards. Emphasis is placed instead on the concepts of 'diversity' and 'culture' which reflects government prioritising of difference rather than educational inequality. Moreover, Moorosi contends that the policy for School Principalship Standard is colour-blind leading to a lack of recognition of school principal power in shaping 'race' dynamics in schools. Content analysis enthused with CRT also helps to elicit policy denial of the existence of racism, as opposed to its entrenchment. Consequently, the school principalship standards cannot effectively prepare South African school principals to foster anti-racist leadership practice.

The final article by **Lauri Johnson** – *'Portraits of UK Black and South Asian Headteachers five years on: Leadership retention in the age of academisation'*, completes the focus on school leadership. Adopting a longitudinal life history approach, Johnson re-interviews a group of Black and South Asian headteachers of schools in England, five years after she first interviewed them as new headteachers, to understand the impact of educational policy (related to governance and financial control of educational provision) on their career decisions, progression and development of their professional identities in the intervening period. Johnson reveals how Black and South Asian headteacher school leadership can be affected by the type of school that they lead, and result in professional

experiences which cause them to reflect on what it means to be a leader. Johnson examines the implications of these school leaders experiences for school diversification and retention.

To conclude, Berry and Cook (2019: 86) contend that 'telling stories of one's experiences can provide important lessons for the future'. The stories of educational leadership shared here contain salient lessons for improving the educational leadership experiences of people of color. We hope these articles inspire you to further research the influence of race on diverse, visionary and self-assured educational leaders.

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ⁱ On 20 April 2021 ex-police officer Derek Chauvin was convicted of the murder of George Floyd in Minneapolis, Minnesota. He was found guilty of three charges - second-degree unintentional murder, third-degree murder and second-degree manslaughter (for an explanation of the different charges see Olson, 2021). The verdict marks a pivotal moment in American history and African American peoples' fight against systemic police brutality and racial injustice, as it is rare for a white police officer to be convicted of killing a Black man detained in police custody (BBC News, 2021).

ⁱⁱ Baroness Amos was appointed Master of University College, Oxford in 2019. She is the first Black College head.